

A COURSE ON THE 2026 ISRAELI ELECTION

Israel Votes

Parties, Tribes, and the 2026 Election

Session 1 — The System, the Tribes, and the Map

October 6, 2026 · 21 days to the vote · Rabbi Daniel Bogard · israelielection.org

A blessing over a crowd

The Sages taught in a Tosefta: One who sees multitudes of Israel recites: Blessed...Who knows all secrets. Why is this? He sees a whole nation whose minds are unlike each other and whose faces are unlike each other, and He Who knows all secrets, God, knows what is in each of their hearts.

Ben Zoma once saw a multitude of Israel while standing on a stair on the Temple Mount. He immediately recited: Blessed...Who knows all secrets and Blessed...Who created all these to serve me.

Babylonian Talmud, Berakhot 58a · William Davidson translation

The ten weeks

Part one · Before the vote

Topic	
1	The system, the tribes, and the map (tonight)
2	How we got here, 1977–2026, and what is (and isn't) on the ballot
3	Election night: watching the results come in

Part two · After the vote

Topic	
4	Reading the results and the coalition process
5	The Haredi world
6	Mizrahi Israel
7	Tel Aviv and the shrinking liberal world
8	The settler movement as it actually operates
9	Palestinian citizens of Israel
10	Hebron

The rules

1

national district: the whole country votes as one

120

seats in the Knesset, filled in proportion to the vote

3.25%

of valid votes, or a list wins no seats at all

61

seats for a majority, and in practice to govern

~7.56M

eligible voters in 2026

~172,000

votes needed to clear the threshold in 2026

Unlike the US

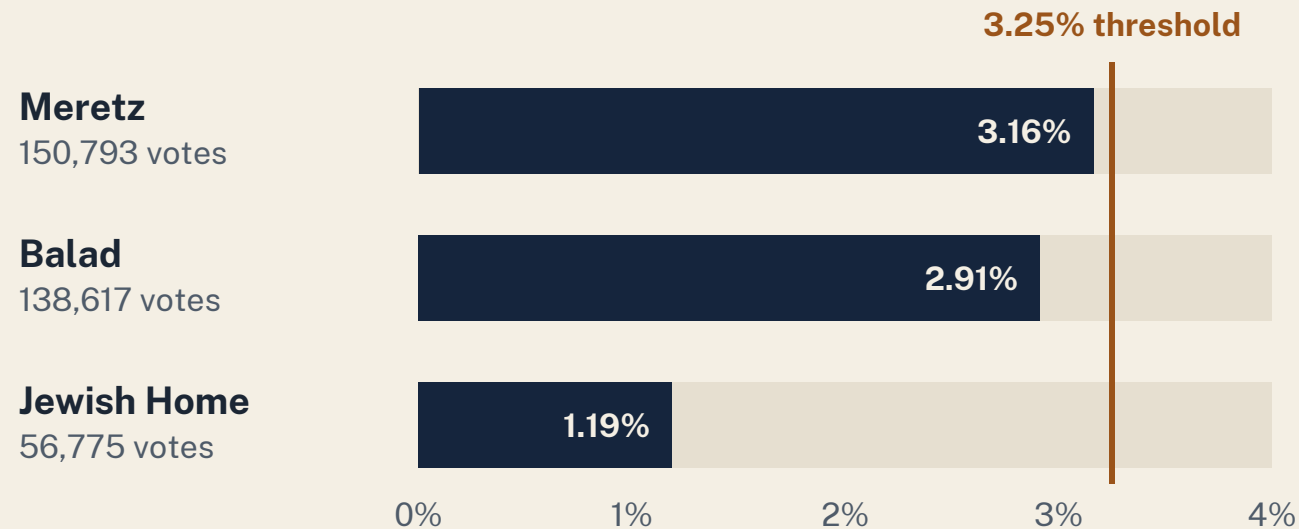
- Closed lists: you vote for a party, not a person. The party ranks its candidates.
- No districts: no local representative, one national count.
- No absentee ballot: with narrow exceptions, you vote in person, in Israel.

The threshold has risen over time, from about 1% to 1.5%, 2%, and now 3.25%. The 3.25% law passed in March 2014 and was first used in 2015.

Sources: Basic Law: The Knesset (Constitute Project); Wikipedia, accessed Oct 4, 2026; IsraelEd, Sep 28, 2026; IDI, 2015, 2020, 2022

Wasted votes

Lists that fell short in 2022, by share of valid votes



8.7%

of all valid votes went to lists that missed the line, a record

64–56

seats, from roughly 2.36 million vs 2.33 million bloc votes

~3,800–4,000

votes: how far Meretz fell short

How seats are handed out

Five steps after the polls close

- 1 Throw out every vote cast for a list under 3.25%.
- 2 Divide the votes that remain by 120. That is the price of one seat (in 2022, 36,227 votes).
- 3 Each list gets one seat for every full price it collected. A few seats are left over (7 in 2022).
- 4 Leftover seats go out one at a time: divide each list's votes by its seats plus one; the biggest number wins a seat. Recalculate and repeat. Paired lists count as one.
- 5 If a pair wins a seat, the same rule decides which partner gets it.

Surplus-vote agreements

Two lists can sign an agreement before the election to be treated as one list when the leftover seats are handed out. It counts only if both lists pass the threshold.

SIGNED FOR 2026

- Yashar + The Democrats
- B'Yachad + Yisrael Beiteinu

2022, worked

4,347,342 votes above the line $\div 120 = \mathbf{36,227}$ a seat. Whole seats: 113. Left over: 7.

List or pair	Votes	Whole seats	$\div (\text{seats} + 1)$
Shas + UTJ	673,158	17	37,397.67
National Unity + Yesh Atid	1,279,917	34	36,569.06
Likud + Rel. Zionism	1,631,806	44	36,262.36
Hadash-Ta'al	178,735	4	35,747.00
Yisrael Beiteinu	213,687	5	35,614.50
Labor	175,992	4	35,198.40
Ra'am	194,047	5	32,341.17

History: the Knesset adopted this method in 1973, named for MKs Yohanan Bader (Gahal) and Avraham Ofer (Alignment), in part “to strengthen the larger parties.”

The seven leftover seats

1. Shas + UTJ
 2. National Unity + Yesh Atid
 3. Likud + Rel. Zionism
 4. Hadash-Ta'al
 5. Yisrael Beiteinu
 6. National Unity + Yesh Atid
 7. Likud + Rel. Zionism
- Labor and Ra'am get none.

INSIDE LIKUD + RZ

Likud $1,115,336 \div 31 = 35,978.58$ beats RZ
 $516,470 \div 15 = 34,431.33$. Likud's next figure,
34,854.25, still wins.

Likud takes both: 32 seats instead of 30. RZ
stays at 14.

Who votes, who doesn't

Can vote

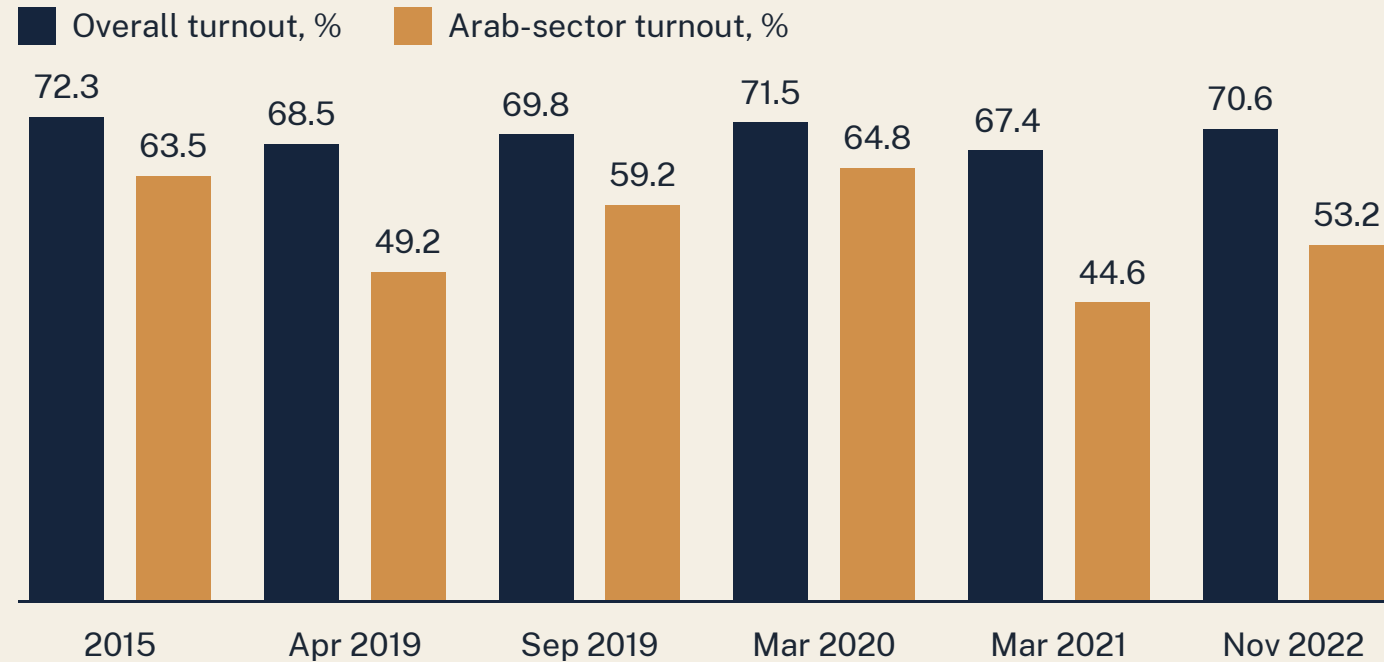
- Citizens 18 and over, including settlers, who vote inside the occupied West Bank
- Soldiers, at polling stations that open 72 hours early
- Diplomats and official emissaries abroad, including Jewish Agency shlichim
- Hospital patients, prisoners and voters with disabilities
- These special ballots use double envelopes and are counted after election night

Cannot vote

- Israelis living abroad: there is no absentee ballot
- Roughly 408,000 Arab residents of Jerusalem, nearly all in East Jerusalem: permanent residents, not citizens. They may vote in city elections, not for the Knesset.
- Golan Druze who hold residency only. Over 35% (about 10,000) now hold citizenship.

Election day is a national holiday. Candidates must be 21 or older.

Turnout



ARAB-SECTOR SWING

64.8% March 2020

44.6% March 2021

One year apart. Overall turnout ranged 67.4–72.3% across all six.

EXPECTED IN 2026

Arab-sector turnout ~53% expected; a survey put it at 67% for a hypothetical four-party list including Ra'am, which did not happen (Dayan Center/KAP, May 2026).

The 2015 Arab-sector figure is the Dayan Center's; another calculation puts it at 52%.

Overall: official results via Wikipedia per-election articles. Arab sector: IDI/Rudnitzky, Sep 23 2019; Mar 10 2020; Apr 27 2021; Dec 25 2022; 2015 Dayan Center, May 20 2019. 2026: Konrad Adenauer Program/Dayan Center survey, May 2026

From vote to government

Oct 27	Nov 4	By Nov 11	28 days	28 days	21 days	90 days
Election day. Diplomats abroad vote Oct 20.	Results certified.	The President consults the factions and assigns the mandate.	First candidate tries to form a government. Up to 14 more days.	If that fails, a second candidate tries.	Any 61 MKs may name someone, who then gets 14 days.	Otherwise the Knesset dissolves; new election within 90 days.

50+ days

No government has been sworn in less than 50 days after an election in two decades. Historically, 20 to 100 days.

61

A new government takes office by winning a confidence vote in the Knesset, which in practice means 61.

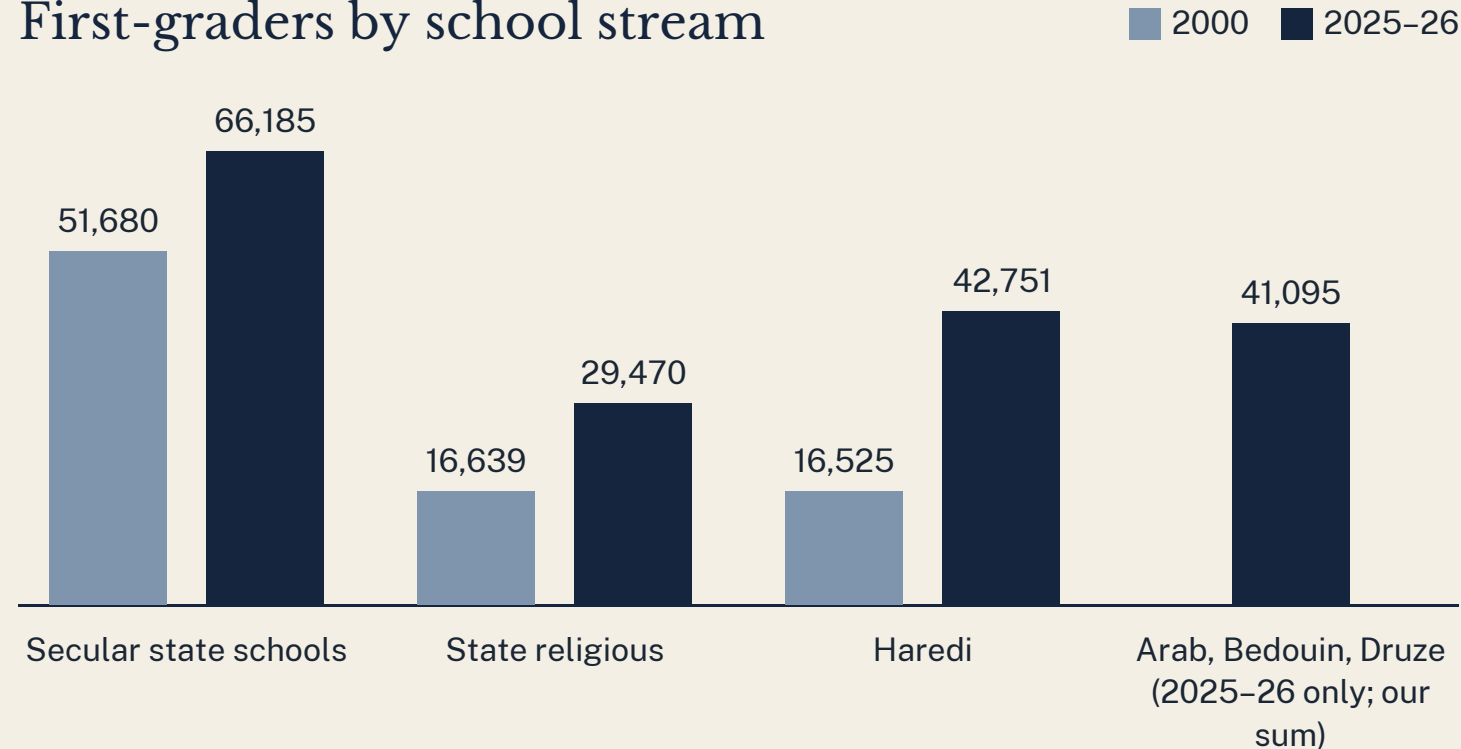
Why five elections in under four years

Apr 9, 2019	Liberman refuses to join over the Haredi draft law. On May 30 the Knesset dissolves itself, the first time before any government was formed.
Sep 17, 2019	Deadlock. No one can form a government; the last 21-day window closes December 11.
Mar 2, 2020	Netanyahu and Gantz agree to rotate (April 20), sworn in May 17. The Knesset dissolves over the budget, December 23, 2020.
Mar 23, 2021	Bennett and Lapid are sworn in June 13, with Ra'am the first independent Arab party in a coalition. Dissolved June 30, 2022.
Nov 1, 2022	The Netanyahu bloc wins 64 seats.

Then the 25th Knesset served its full term, the first to do so since 1988. It dissolved on July 17, 2026.

The first-grade classroom, 2000 → 2025–26

First-graders by school stream



72,221

religious first-graders, 2025–26:
state religious plus Haredi (our
sum)

66,185

secular first-graders, 2025–26

For the first time, religious first-graders
outnumber secular ones.

President Rivlin called these four school streams Israel's “four tribes” in 2015; today's numbers are from the Education Ministry, Aug 2025.

Sources: Education Ministry data via Times of Israel, Aug 31, 2025; Rivlin speech, Jun 7, 2015 (Reichman University text)

More than four tribes: Israel in 2026

Group	Best estimate	The number behind it	How it voted in 2022, or key fact
Secular (hiloni)	~29% [arith]	39.6% of Jewish adults (CBS, Sep 2026)	Yesh Atid 39, Likud 20
Masortim	~26% [arith]	35.8% of Jewish adults [arith]	Likud 46.5, RZ–Otzma 14
National-religious	~9% [arith]	12.4% of Jewish adults; JPPI: 16–17%	RZ–Otzma 45, Likud 22.5
Haredim	14.3%	Lithuanian 34%, Sephardi 32%, Hasidic 29%, Chabad 4% (Machon, Dec 2024)	UTJ 58, Shas 28
Arab citizens	21.7%	Muslims 1.849M; Christians 184,200; Druze ~152k; Negev Bedouin ~325k	Turnout 53.2%: Ra'am 35, Hadash–Ta'al 29, Balad 22
Russian-speakers*	~15% of voters	~1M eligible voters	2025 poll: YB 23%, Bennett 17%
Settlers*	~5.25% (West Bank)	540k West Bank + ~234k East Jerusalem	36% Haredi / 36% RZ / 28% secular; RZ 22% in settlements vs 11% nationally (2022)
Ethiopian Israelis	~1.8% [arith]	177,600 (CBS, 2024)	No voting study found

Shares are of all residents. * Cuts across the other groups. [arith] = our arithmetic: Jewish-adult share × Jews' ~73.6% of the population; undercounts young Haredim. 2022 vote = % of each group's vote (IDI, Jun 28, 2026; Arab: IDI, Dec 25, 2022).

Sources: CBS via Ynet/VIN, Sep 9, 2026; IDI, Dec 14, 2025 & Jun 28, 2026; Machon, Dec 2024; JPPI, Sep 2025; CBS via TPS, May 2026; Lazar/JPost, Dec 2025; Yesha, Feb 2026; EU, Aug 2025; Yesha via Tol, May 2023; Washington Institute, Nov 2022; CBS via JNS, Nov 2025

Who Israelis are, by the newest numbers

POPULATION, SEPTEMBER 2026

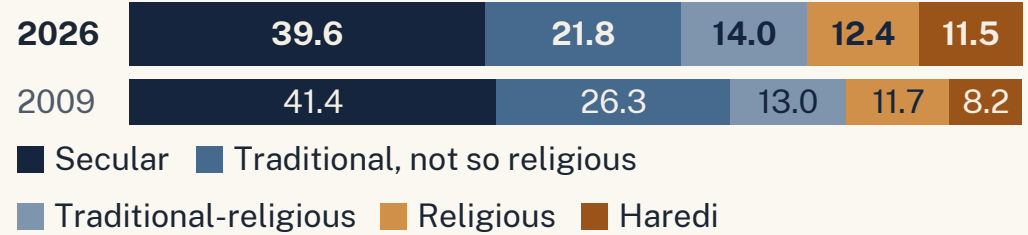
10,305,000

Jews and others 78.3%

Arabs 21.7%

CBS, Sep 9, 2026. Shares exclude 304,000 foreign nationals.

JEWS 20+ BY RELIGIOSITY, %



JEWS BY SELF-IDENTIFIED ORIGIN (IDI 2025)

39.8% 35.2% 15.3%

Ashkenazi

Mizrahi

Mixed

Former Soviet Union immigrants 5.3% · Ethiopian 0.6%

~81% of Jews are Israeli-born (CBS, Apr 2026).

HAREDIM

14.3% ~22%

of Israelis now (IDI)

by 2050 (IDI, Feb 2026)

CBS's own projection, still 2017-based, runs higher: 24.4% by 2050.

Emigration: 59,400 / 82,800 / 69,500 left in 2023 / 2024 / 2025 (CBS, revised). A TAU study runs higher.

Likud

Who they are

Founded 1973 by Begin and Sharon; one party since 1988. Took power in 1977 with 43 seats. Netanyahu has led it since 2005. Aug 17, 2026 primary: Eli Cohen first; Tol called it a “win for Netanyahu bid to reshape sinking party.”

Who votes for them

2022: 1,115,336 votes, 23.4%, 32 seats (seats since 2019: 35 · 32 · 36 · 30 · 32). Its 2022 voters: 57% traditional, 32% secular, 10% national-religious (IDI). First-time voters 2026: Likud 14%, Yashar 16% (N12).

What they’re running on

Haredi draft	Netanyahu revived the exemption bill (Tol, May 2026)
Courts	New judge-selection law: professionals lose veto next term
The war & Gaza	Rejected Trump’s 15-point plan; no Palestinian state
West Bank	Likud ministers urged “apply sovereignty” (Jul 2025)
Religion & state	No 2026 position found
Economy	No 2026 position found
Netanyahu’s trial	Pardon asked Nov 2025; Herzog pushing a plea deal

Benjamin Netanyahu

Born Oct 21, 1949, Tel Aviv. Sayeret Matkal; UN ambassador 1984–88. PM 1996–99, 2009–21 and since Dec 2022. On trial since May 2020.

ON THE LIST

2 Eli Cohen
5 Gideon Sa’ar · 7 Yariv Levin
9 Talik Gvili, mother of Ran Gvili, the last hostage returned

COALITION

Netanyahu: “a strong right-wing government led by me – or a weak l[eft]...” Surplus partner: Religious Zionism (agreed Sep 8; signing unconfirmed).

“We’ll wait for the next term, when two-thirds of the Supreme Court justices’ seats become vacant... You’ll simply go extinct.”

Yariv Levin, Kan recordings, via JTA, Sep 18, 2026

Netanyahu bloc · Aryeh Deri · Seats in latest polls: 7–10

Shas — Shomrei Sefarad

Who they are

Founded 1984 as “Shomrei Sefarad,” protesting thin Sephardi representation in Agudat Yisrael, under Rav Ovadia Yosef. Peak: 17 seats in 1999. In Aug 2026 council head Rabbi Moshe Maya chose former Chief Rabbi Yitzhak Yosef “to lead” (JPost).

Who votes for them

28% of Haredim and 10.5% of national-religious voters chose Shas in 2022 (IDI). IDI’s Malach: “at least three or four Knesset seats’ worth of voters who are simply not Haredi.” 2022: 392,964 votes, 8.25%, 11 seats (since 2019: 8 · 9 · 9 · 9 · 11).

What they’re running on

Haredi draft	Bill to enshrine Torah study as a basic value
Courts	“Fundamentally reform the judicial system” (Ynet)
The war & Gaza	Dismantle Hamas; no indefinite control (JPost’s summary)
West Bank	Opposes a Palestinian state; “not central” (Ynet)
Religion & state	Orthodox control of marriage, conversion, kashrut
Economy	Deri: poor Haredi children owed equal minimum support

Aryeh Deri

Born Feb 17, 1959, Meknes; immigrated 1968. Interior minister 1988. Bribery conviction 1999, 22 months. Supreme Court barred him from the cabinet, Jan 2023.

ON THE LIST

1 Aryeh Deri · 2 Yinon Azoulay
3 Michael Malkieli
6 Lt.-Col. (res.) Dror Amos, 25 years in the IDF

COALITION

Deri: “We support Netanyahu, period” (Jul 16). Anonymous report: opposition until a draft law passes. Surplus partner: UTJ expected; signing not found.

“The army doesn’t want haredi soldiers, get that into your head.”
Aryeh Deri, Sep 3, 2026, via JPost

Netanyahu bloc · Yaakov Asher · Seats in latest polls: 7–8

United Torah Judaism — Yahadut HaTorah

Who they are

Joint list of Agudat Yisrael (Hasidic) and Degel HaTorah (Lithuanian) since 1992. Quit the government July 2025 over the draft. Sept 2026: Rav Landau dropped Gafni and Maklev; Porush and Stark formed a third faction, Homat Torat Yisrael.

Who votes for them

58% of Haredim voted UTJ in 2022; 86% UTJ or Shas (IDI). 2022: 280,194 votes, 5.88%, 7 seats (since 2019: 8 · 7 · 7 · 7 · 7). 2021: Modi'in Illit 78%, Bnei Brak 60.9% (Tol). 45% of Haredi first-time voters (N12).

What they're running on

Haredi draft	No government without a law on Torah learners' status
Courts	"The Supreme Court has accumulated excessive power" (party position as reported by Ynet, Sep 2026)
The war & Gaza	"Focuses primarily on domestic issues" (JPost)
West Bank	No unified policy; Degel "more moderate" (Ynet)
Religion & state	As Shas: Orthodox control of marriage and conversion
Economy	Housing for Haredi communities; yeshiva funding

Yaakov Asher (Degel HaTorah)

Born July 2, 1965, Ramat Gan. Mayor of Bnei Brak from 2008; MK since 2013 (some sources: 2016). Quit as Interior Committee chair over the draft.

ON THE LIST

- 1 Yaakov Asher (Degel)
- 2 Goldknopf (Agudah/Gur)
- 4 Meir Porush · 6 Elyakim Stark (Homat Torat Yisrael)

COALITION

No government without a yeshiva-status law, whoever leads. Asher denied a report that two MKs might let Eisenkot form a government. Surplus partner: Shas expected; signing not found.

"We no longer have trust in Netanyahu."
Rav Dov Landau, letter (JPost, May 25, 2026)

Netanyahu bloc · Bezalel Smotrich · Seats in latest polls: 5–7

Religious Zionism–Zehut

Who they are

Roots in Tkuma, which split from the National Religious Party in 1998. Smotrich chair since 2019. Ran with Otzma in 2022 for 14 seats, then split. Refused a 2026 joint run with Ben-Gvir; on Sep 1 formed a technical bloc with Feiglin’s Zehut.

Who votes for them

Draws “mainstream Religious Zionists” (Finkelstein). 2022 joint list: 516,470 votes, 10.84%, 14 seats; 45% of national-religious voters (IDI). It won 22% in settlements vs ~11% nationally (Washington Institute).

What they’re running on

Haredi draft	Most MKs backed the Jul 14 arrest ban; Solomon voted no
Courts	Justices chosen by all judges; 61-vote override
The war & Gaza	“Return to the whole of Gaza in a big way”
West Bank	103 new settlements approved; “abolish the Oslo Accords”
Religion & state	“Jewish identity in state institutions and education”
Economy	Competition-based solutions; Zehut: flat tax, vouchers
Netanyahu’s trial	Smotrich: Netanyahu “persecuted for years by a corrupt judicial system that fabricated political cases”

Bezalel Smotrich

Born Feb 27, 1980, Haspin (Golan); lives in Kedumim. Co-founded Regavim. Finance Minister since 2022, also over West Bank civil affairs. Sanctioned by several countries since 2025.

ON THE LIST

2 Moshe Feiglin (Zehut) · 3 Orit Strock
4 Simcha Rothman
New: Reut Ben Haim, Tzav 9 founder

COALITION

Netanyahu for PM; rules out Arab parties. Surplus partner: Likud (agreed Sep 8; unsigned as of Sep 15).

“Every settlement... is another nail in the coffin of this dangerous idea.”

Smotrich, on approving about 3,400 E1 housing units, Aug 20, 2025, via Tol

Netanyahu bloc · Itamar Ben-Gvir · Seats in latest polls: 6–9

Otzma Yehudit — Jewish Power

Who they are

Founded Nov 2012. Israel Policy Forum describes it as the “ideological continuation” of Kahane’s movement; Kach was outlawed in 1994. Ben-Gvir leader since 2019; 6 seats in 2022 on a joint list. Left government Jan 2025 over the ceasefire; back in Mar 2025.

Who votes for them

“Traditional Mizrahi voters from the periphery” (Finkelstein). Below the threshold on its own before 2021: 1.88% in Sep 2019, 0.42% in 2020. Has 13% of Haredi first-time voters (N12).

What they’re running on

Haredi draft	Haredi police tracks: “enter service as Haredi and leave it as Haredi”
Courts	Backed the 2023 overhaul; political control of appointments
The war & Gaza	“Disengagement 710”: 250,000 Gaza departures a year
West Bank	No Palestinian state; no evacuating settlers
Religion & state	Temple Mount: “Jews are praying and feel that they are the rightful owners of this place” (Jul 2026)
Economy	No 2026 position found
Netanyahu’s trial	“I hope President Trump will put an end to this farce”

Itamar Ben-Gvir

Born May 6, 1976, Mevaseret Zion, to Iraqi-Jewish parents; lives in Kiryat Arba. Ex-Kach youth coordinator; 2007 conviction for incitement to racism. National Security Minister since 2022.

ON THE LIST

2 Tally Gotliv (ex-Likud)
3 Yitzhak Wasserlauf · 4 Amichai Eliyahu
12 Yishai Fleisher, Hebron spokesman

COALITION

A “fully right-wing government”: no centrists, no Arab parties. Wants Defense or Justice. Surplus partner: none found.

“I want to kill you. I want to put you to death.”
Ben-Gvir to a Hamas prisoner in a campaign video; ordered removed Oct 3, 2026 (JPost)

Sources: Tol Apr 15 & Jan 27 2026 · JPost Jul 23, Sep 3, Sep 24 & Oct 3 2026 · JTA Sep 6 2026 · polls Sep 28–Oct 2 2026

Amcha Yisrael — People of Israel

Who they are

New in 2026. Winter left the IDF in May 2024 after being passed over for major general, and turned down a Likud slot. Launched Aug 25, 2026 in Jerusalem. Refused Smotrich’s merger despite pressure from rabbis.

Who votes for them

Targets younger voters, reservists and right-wingers who can’t back the current government (JPost, Sep 17). No earlier results; no sector data found. Channel 14 has it below the threshold.

What they’re running on

Haredi draft	A law ending draft evasion before joining. “Full stop.”
Courts	Calls for a judicial overhaul; no details given
The war & Gaza	“There is one solution in Gaza: migration”
West Bank	“There will never be a Palestinian state here”
Religion & state	No 2026 position found
Economy	Double combat soldiers’ pay

Ofer Winter

Born Feb 3, 1971, Rekhasim. IDF 1990–2024: commanded Duvdevan, Givati and the 98th Division. On Oct 7 went to the Be’eri front on his own.

ON THE LIST

- 2 Yoseph Haddad, Arab Orthodox Christian; wounded Golani volunteer
- 3 Netali Shem Tov, journalist
- 5 Fleur Hassan-Nahoum, ex-deputy mayor of Jerusalem

COALITION

Recommends only Netanyahu. Reports conflict on whether he’d sit with Bennett or Liberman; opposes Eisenkot at Defense (JPost Sep 2, Sep 17; Ynet Oct 4). Surplus partner: none.

“I want to work for Shfaram and Nazareth, not for Gaza and Jenin.”
Yoseph Haddad, no. 2, via JFeed, Sep 14, 2026

Yashar! — Straight

Who they are

Founded Sept 16, 2025 by Gadi Eisenkot, two months after he resigned from the Knesset, with about 120 co-founders. Joined in 2026 by ex-Shin Bet chief Yoram Cohen, Orit Farkash-Hacohen, Elazar Stern and Adi Altschuler. A new list with no seat history.

Who votes for them

Aims at “Route 4” suburbs (Petah Tikva, Kiryat Ono, Holon) and former Likud voters (Tol). Largest share of first-time voters: 16% (N12/Midgam). No 2022 result.

What they’re running on

Haredi draft	“National Service for All”; deferments capped at 3%
Courts	Repeal the judicial-selection law; no override clause
The war & Gaza	Opposes Board of Peace plan as “leaving Hamas in power”
West Bank	Opposes a Palestinian state (Tol Sep 26; JTA Sep 9); the JC reports him calling the question “largely irrelevant” (Oct 4)
Religion & state	“A secular party, but not anti-religious” (JC)
Economy	Conscript pay +15%; reserve duty capped at 50 days a year

Gadi Eisenkot · b. 1960, Tiberias

Son of Moroccan immigrants. IDF chief of staff 2015–19. His son Gal was killed in Gaza in Dec 2023.

ON THE LIST

- 2 · Yoram Cohen, ex-Shin Bet chief
- 3 · Orit Farkash-Hacohen
- 6 · Chili Tropper

COALITION

Any Zionist party that accepts his four principles. Not Ra’am. Surplus partner: the Democrats.

“Not about right or left, but straight.”

Freed hostage Eli Sharabi, the source of the name (Tol, Sep 16, 2025)

Anti-Netanyahu bloc (Jewish-majority parties) · Naftali Bennett · Seats in latest polls: 8–13

B'Yachad — Together

Who they are

Bennett's list, registered April 2025. On April 26, 2026 Yair Lapid's Yesh Atid joined it, with Bennett as PM candidate and Lapid at no. 2. Not a formal merger.

Who votes for them

Yesh Atid 2022: 847,435 votes, 17.79%, 24 seats; its voters 78.5% secular (IDI). Polling fell from ~25 seats in May to about half (Tol).

What they’re running on

Haredi draft	Service for all “without exemptions”
Courts	Repeal the appointments law; Basic Law on review
The war & Gaza	Hold the red line “until Hamas is disarmed”
West Bank	No Palestinian state; legal settlement in Area C
Religion & state	Civil marriage; local choice on Shabbat transit
Economy	“Cut food prices by 30% within three years”
Netanyahu's trial	Bennett would back a binding arrangement: “respectful retirement from political life alongside the end of the trial”

Naftali Bennett · b. 1972, Haifa

Son of American immigrants. Sayeret Matkal; tech founder. Prime minister 2021–22.

ON THE LIST

2 · Yair Lapid
3 · Keren Turner, ex-finance DG
12 · Ram Ben Barak

COALITION

Zionist parties only; no Arab or Haredi parties.
Surplus partner: Yisrael Beiteinu.

“I’m a right-wing guy, I’m not changing my opinions. But I’m not a schmuck.”

Naftali Bennett (Tol, Jun 23, 2026)

Anti-Netanyahu bloc (Jewish-majority parties) · Yair Golan · Seats in latest polls: 8–11

The Democrats — HaDemokratim

Who they are

Labor (1968; PMs Meir, Rabin, Peres) and Meretz (1992), joined under Golan in 2024. A partial merger: each keeps its own institutions (IDI). Protest leaders joined in 2026.

Who votes for them

2022: Labor 3.69%, 4 seats; Meretz 3.16%, 0 seats, its first time out. Together 16% of the secular vote (IDI).

What they’re running on

Haredi draft	Universal service; benefits go to those who serve
Courts	Opposes the 2023 overhaul; fix delays, add judges
The war & Gaza	“Topple the Hamas regime” (IDI)
West Bank	Opposes annexation; defund outposts
Religion & state	Civil marriage; amend the Nation-State Law
Economy	Lower living costs; better social services
Netanyahu's trial	“Zero criminal defendants” in its government

Yair Golan · b. 1962, Rishon LeZion

Deputy chief of staff 2014–17. On Oct 7 went south himself and rescued Nova survivors.

ON THE LIST

- 2 · Naama Lazimi
- 3 · Gilad Kariv
- 9 · Moshe Radman, protest leader

COALITION

No Likud, no Haredi parties. Open to an Arab party in government. Surplus partner: Yashar!

“Jewish-Arab partnership in government is a positive thing. That is absolutely our future.”

The Democrats’ statement, as reported by Tol, Oct 3, 2026 (speaker not named in the report)

Anti-Netanyahu bloc (Jewish-majority parties) · Avigdor Liberman · Seats in latest polls: 6–10

Yisrael Beiteinu — Israel Our Home

Who they are

Founded 1999 for immigrants from the former Soviet Union; peak of 15 seats in 2009. Liberman's April 2019 refusal over the draft law set off five elections.

Who votes for them

23% of Russian-speakers (Lazar, Dec 2025). 2022: 213,687 votes, 4.48%, 6 seats; between 5 and 8 seats in each election since 2015 (6, 5, 8, 7, 7, 6 — our reading of the results).

What they’re running on

Haredi draft	Everyone at 18; sanctions include travel bans
Courts	A written constitution, put to a referendum
The war & Gaza	Board of Peace plan is “a capitulation to terror”
West Bank	“The Palestinian Authority must be dismantled”
Religion & state	Civil marriage; local Shabbat choice; core curriculum
Economy	“Right-wing fiscal positions” (IDI)
Netanyahu's trial	“A state in exchange for a pardon” (Feb 2026)

Avigdor Liberman · b. 1958

Born in Chişinău; immigrated 1978. Defense minister 2016–18; lives in Nokdim.

ON THE LIST

2 · Rafi Ben Shitrit, ex-mayor
6 · Sharon Sharabi, Eli's brother
10 · Dan Illouz, ex-Likud MK

COALITION

No Netanyahu, no Arab or Haredi parties. Surplus partner: B'Yachad.

“We are the Likud of yesteryear.”

Campaign slogan (Ynet, Sep 27, 2026)

Reservists–Economic Party

Who they are

Founded Sept 18, 2025 by Yoaz Hendel, a former communications minister. An alliance with Chili Tropper (July 2026) ended when Tropper left for Yashar on Sep 6. Now a technical list with Yaron Zelekha’s New Economic Party.

Who votes for them

No seats in 2022; Zelekha’s party took 0.29% then. Hendel pitches an alternative to a Haredi-backed or an Arab-backed government (Maariv). Sector data: not found.

What they’re running on

Haredi draft	Draft law must pass before a government is sworn in
Courts	Reform; 8-year term limits; a constitution
The war & Gaza	Wilf: “full perimeter control”; a “voluntary emigration directorate for Gaza”
West Bank	No Palestinian state; supports settlement
Religion & state	No 2026 position found
Economy	Zelekha: break up the monopolies that raise prices

Yoaz Hendel

Born 1975, Petah Tikva; raised in Elkana. Shayetet 13; reserve lieutenant-colonel, commanded Battalion 8555 in the 2023 war. Communications minister 2020 and 2021–22.

ON THE LIST

2 Prof. Yaron Zelekha, accountant-general 2003–07
3 Einat Wilf, ex-Labor MK
4 Haviv Volibovich

COALITION

A Zionist government only: no Haredi or Arab parties. On Netanyahu, Hendel’s statements conflict. Surplus partner: unconfirmed.

“Those who do not serve cannot vote or be elected to the Knesset.”
Reservists party website (themiluimnikim.org.il), read Oct 4, 2026

Joint List and Ra'am · Yousef Jabareen · Seats in latest polls: 7–9

The Joint List — Hadash–Ta'al–Balad

Who they are

Formed 2015 by all four Arab-led parties; peak of 15 seats in 2020; split by 2021. Re-formed Aug 19, 2026 without Ra'am. Barred by the Elections Committee Sept 23; reinstated 9–0 by the Supreme Court Oct 2.

Who votes for them

2022 in Arab and Druze towns: Hadash–Ta'al 28.8%, Balad 21.7% (IDI). Nationally: Hadash–Ta'al 3.75%, 5 seats; Balad 2.91%, no seats.

What they're running on

Haredi draft	No 2026 position found
Courts	No 2026 position found
The war & Gaza	“End Gaza destruction” (New Arab)
West Bank	A Palestinian state alongside Israel; “stop settlement expansion” (New Arab)
Religion & state	No 2026 position found
Economy	No 2026 position found

Yousef Jabareen · b. 1972

From Umm al-Fahm; constitutional-law scholar. Hadash chair since May 2026, replacing Ayman Odeh.

ON THE LIST

- 2 · Ahmad Tibi (Ta'al)
- 3 · Sami Abu Shehadeh, withdrew
- 6 · Ofer Cassif (per The New Arab, Sep 9; slot order differs by source)

COALITION

Won't join Netanyahu. Sets conditions for backing an Eisenkot bloc. Surplus partner: Ra'am.

“We agreed on the Joint List because the interests of our people are greater than any disagreement.”

Yousef Jabareen, on the Aug 19 deal (outlet not recorded)

Joint List and Ra'am · Mansour Abbas · Seats in latest polls: 5 in all five

Ra'am — United Arab List

Who they are

Founded 1996 as the political wing of the Islamic Movement's Southern Branch. In 2021, the first independent Arab party in an Israeli government. Says its split from the movement's Shura Council was complete in July 2026.

Who votes for them

2022: 4.07%, 5 seats; 35.2% of the Arab and Druze vote, 73.9% in the Negev (IDI).
Strongholds: Negev and Triangle.

What they’re running on

Haredi draft	No 2026 position found
Courts	No 2026 position found
The war & Gaza	Asked on Kan (Jul 28) if Hamas is a terror group to be destroyed: “I don't want to give you a straight answer... I have a straight answer; I just don't want to say it”
West Bank	Wants Israel and the US to recognize Palestine
Religion & state	“Israel was born as a Jewish state, and it will remain so” (earlier statement, date not recorded)
Economy	Budgets, planning, housing and jobs for Arab towns

Mansour Abbas · b. 1974, Maghar

Dentist and imam. Ra'am chair since 2018, MK since 2019.

ON THE LIST

2 · Yoav Segalovitz, Jewish former police commander
Also on the slate: Walid Taha, Iman Khatib-Yassin

COALITION

Open to any coalition, Likud-led included. Eisenkot says no. Surplus partner: the Joint List.

“I am going to an Arab party. They are not coming to me.”

Yoav Segalovitz, on joining (Aug 2026; outlet not recorded)

The map by bloc

Netanyahu bloc · 51–54 seats in the four latest polls			
Likud	Netanyahu	 19–21	Channel 14 polls: 30–32
Shas	Deri	 7–9	Reservist Dror Amos at no. 6
United Torah Judaism	Asher; Goldknopf no. 2	 7–8	Not split; Porush's new faction at no. 4
Religious Zionism–Zehut	Smotrich, with Feiglin	 5–7	Two parties on one list
Otzma Yehudit	Ben-Gvir	 6–9	“Ideological heir to Kahane’s Kach” (Israel Policy Forum’s description)
People of Israel	Winter	 4–5	Haredi enlistment “without compromise”
Noam	Maoz	no polls found	Running alone
Anti-Netanyahu bloc (Jewish-majority parties) · 49–53 seats			
Yashar!	Eisenkot	 21–23	Pledges a state commission of inquiry
B'Yachad	Bennett; Lapid no. 2	 10–13	Yesh Atid runs inside this list
The Democrats	Golan	 8–11	Labor and Meretz; two states
Yisrael Beiteinu	Liberman	 9–10	Secular; the Haredi draft is its signature issue
Blue and White	Gantz	under 3.25%	Below the threshold in every poll
Between the blocs			
Reservists–Economic Party	Hendel / Zelekha / Wilf	 0–5	Sources disagree on its bloc
Joint List and Ra'am · 12–14 seats · counted separately			
Joint List	Jabareen; Tibi no. 2	 7–9	Hadash–Ta'al–Balad, re-formed Aug 19
Ra'am	Abbas; Segalovitz no. 2	 5	No. 2 is a Jewish former police commander

Seat ranges = low and high across the four polls on the next slide (Sep 28–Oct 2); bars = our average · Ch 13’s “below threshold” counted as 0

The polls

Netanyahu bloc

List	Maariv	Ch 13	Zman	Kan
Likud	19	19	21	21
Otzma Yehudit	9	8	6	7
Shas	7	7	9	–
UTJ	7	8	8	–
Rel. Zionism–Zehut	5	7	5	6
People of Israel	4	5	4	4
Bloc total	51	54	53	52

The outlier: Channel 14 (Sep 27) has Likud at 32 and the Netanyahu bloc at 63.

Kan did not report Shas and UTJ separately.

Opposition and other lists

List	Maariv	Ch 13	Zman	Kan
Yashar!	21	21	21	23
B'Yachad	13	11	10	11
The Democrats	10	11	8	9
Yisrael Beiteinu	9	9	10	9
Opposition total	53	52	49	52
Joint List	7	9	8	7
Ra'am	5	5	5	5
Joint List and Ra'am	12	14	13	12
Reservists	4	below	5	4

Since mid-September

SEP 23 → OCT 2

Elections Committee votes to bar the Joint List and Ra'am; Supreme Court reinstates them

Sep 23: the Committee votes to bar Ra'am and the Joint List (each 18–5), Cassif (19–5) and Abu Shehadeh (30–4). Oct 2: the Court reinstates both lists 9–0 and Cassif 7–2. Abu Shehadeh withdrew.

SEP 20

Gantz may step aside

Blue and White is under the 3.25% threshold in every poll. Benny Gantz says he will leave the race in the last week if it is still under.

SEP 19

Flying voters home

Israelis abroad have no absentee vote (diplomats, emissaries and ships' crews excepted); Likud fights a campaign to fly expats home.

Discussion

What do you think this election is about?

We'll write the answers down and come back to them on election night, October 27.

NEXT WEEK

How we got here, 1977–2026